

RAJWANT RAWAT

MAYANK PRAJAPATI
AGE: 32

Freelance architect

PLAYING COMPETITIVELY SINCE: 2015

GAME: *Street Fighter 5, part of India's Asian Games contingent*

AKSHAJ SHENOY
AGE: 22

Student of HR, Economics, Sociology at St Joseph's College, Bengaluru

PLAYING COMPETITIVELY SINCE: 2019

GAME: *Captain of India's League of Legends team at the Asian Games*

ASHISH K VINCENT



WHEN MAYANK PRAJAPATI ISN'T CHANGING HIS TWO-YEAR-OLD SON'S DIAPERS, he is busy breaking legs and cracking heads in Street Fighter V, a 'fighting' video game in which two players use a variety of special techniques and 'characters' to knock out opponents. "It is pretty difficult...I don't sleep at all," says Prajapati about his balancing act as a freelance architect, a stay-at-home dad and a committed competitive gamer. He is amongst the growing legion of diehard Indian Esports enthusiasts—competitive video gaming where people play against each other online and at spectator events in indoor arenas. Having played Street Fighter for two decades and after winning multiple tournaments in India, 32-year-old Prajapati awaits his finest hour. He will represent India at the Asian Games at Hangzhou, China, where Esports makes its debut as a medal event. It gives Prajapati bragging rights to another vocation: an 'Esports athlete'. "It is pretty satisfying to say that you play video games and represent India," he says. "People just don't believe it."

Prajapati is part of the 15-member